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Is Macbeth a Tragic Hero?

Macbeth can be considered a tragic hero because his character comprises noble qualities and a fatal flaw that leads to his downfall. In Shakespearean drama, a tragic hero is usually a person of high status whose own choices contribute to their tragic end. At the start of the play, Macbeth is portrayed as brave and honorable. He is praised as “**brave Macbeth**” who fought loyally for King Duncan (Act 1, Scene 2), showing that he begins as a respected hero.

The incidence of the witches’ prophecy introduces temptation, but Macbeth’s ambition quickly becomes the predominant force guiding his actions. He admits that he has “**no spur / To prick the sides of my intent, but only / Vaulting ambition**” (Act 1, Scene 7), clearly identifying his tragic flaw. As a result, his priority shifts from loyalty to the desire for power, leading him to murder Duncan.

Ultimately, Macbeth recognizes the emptiness of his actions when he reflects that **“Life’s but a walking shadow”** (Act 5, Scene 5). His death restores order to Scotland and reinforces the tragic lesson of the play. Because Macbeth’s downfall is caused by his own ambition and choices, he fits the definition of a Shakespearean tragic hero.